

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Medieval History 06

Decline of the Sultanate: Timur, Sayyids and Lodis



How to read Topic 06

- Theme: Delhi contracts, India regionalises, north India transitions.
- Rule: Do not reduce decline to weak rulers, guns alone or all-India collapse.
- Method: Use source criticism, owner boundaries and multi-causal explanation.

Topic-specific transition cover. All route and zone visuals inside are schematic and not to scale.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

Solved topic-specific MCQs

This workbook block contains all practice material that must also be exported separately as the premium solved workbook PDF. The questions are divided into verified-or-honestly-adjacent PYQs, original broad-coverage MCQs, remedial trap MCQs and original Mains answers.

Verified and honestly-adjacent PYQs

PYQ 01 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2021 (adjacent chronology route; wording verified locally, option row partly OCR-garbled)

Question as securely verified from local OCR: Consider the following statements:

1. It was during the reign of Iltutmish that Chengiz Khan reached the Indus in pursuit of the fugitive Khwarezm prince.
2. It was during the reign of Muhammad bin Tughluq that Taimur occupied Multan and crossed the Indus.
3. It was during the reign of Deva Raya II of Vijayanagara Empire that Vasco da Gama reached the coast of Kerala.

Option-row status: The local OCR preserves the combination row imperfectly, but earlier validated repository usage supports the standard set containing "1 only", "1 and 2", "3 only" and "2 and 3".

Inferred answer - not officially verified locally: 1 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is correct because Chinggis Khan reached the Indus in 1221 while pursuing Jalal al-Din Mangburni during Iltutmish's reign. Statement 2 is incorrect because Timur's Indian invasion belongs to the post-Firuz phase and culminates in 1398, far after Muhammad bin Tughlaq. Statement 3 is incorrect because Vasco da Gama reached Kerala in 1498, not in Deva Raya II's time.

Why this earns marks: It secures chronology and prevents the common error of attaching every north-west frontier episode to Muhammad bin Tughlaq.

PYQ 02 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2022 (adjacent frontier chronology; wording verified locally)

Question: With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements:

1. The first Mongol invasion of India happened during the reign of Jalal-ud-din Khalji.
2. During the reign of Ala-ud-din Khalji, one Mongol assault marched up to Delhi and besieged the city.
3. Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq temporarily lost portions of north-west of his kingdom to Mongols.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 (b) 2 only (c) 1 and 3 (d) 3 only

Inferred answer - not officially verified locally: (b) 2 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is incorrect because Mongol pressure on India predates Jalaluddin Khalji. Statement 2 is correct because a major Mongol attack reached Delhi during Alauddin's reign. Statement 3 is not supported in the secure form used in this repository.

Why this earns marks: It separates early frontier pressure from the famous Delhi-siege moment and trains ruler-event discipline.

PYQ 03 - UPSC GS-I 2020 (adjacent but highly useful source-criticism question; wording preserved in repository)

Question: Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

Persian literary sources are indispensable for reconstructing medieval India because they preserve the language of kingship, conquest, moral anxiety, administrative aspiration and courtly self-fashioning. Yet they reflect the spirit of the age only when read with **genre and patronage caution**.

For Topic 06, this method is essential. Timurid victory narratives and later memoir traditions present violence, piety and legitimacy through the conqueror's lens. Yahya bin Ahmad Sirhindi is crucial for the Sayyid world, but he also writes from within a courtly-political frame. *Baburnama* gives vivid first-person detail for the road to Panipat, yet it

remains ruler-self-representation, not neutral reportage. Earlier texts such as Barani and Afif likewise reveal the assumptions of elite Persianate politics more fully than the experience of peasants, women or local vernacular communities.

These works therefore reflect the age in a **refracted** way: they reveal the values of courts, officials, warriors and legitimising intellectuals. Their silence on subaltern life, and their tendency to moralise success and failure, require constant checking against coins, inscriptions, architecture and regional evidence.

Hence Persian literary sources do reflect the spirit of the age - but mainly the political and ideological spirit of elite society. Used critically and comparatively, they become powerful historical evidence rather than decorative quotation.

Why this earns marks: It turns the word *reflect* into a method question, names applicable source families and shows both value and limitation.

PYQ 04 - UPSC GS-I 2023 (adjacent Sultanate-wide technology question; wording preserved in repository)

Question: What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did those technological changes influence the Indian society? (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

The Sultanate period mattered technologically because it accelerated the diffusion, adaptation and systematisation of techniques in construction, irrigation, warfare and administration. Its importance lay less in isolated inventions than in the **social use of technology for state-building**.

In building, the stronger use of the true arch, dome and lime mortar changed both engineering possibility and the symbolism of power. In irrigation, canals associated with Firuz Shah show technology tied directly to agrarian expansion and revenue growth. In administration, branding, descriptive rolls, measurement practices and revenue accounting improved the capacity of rulers to supervise men, horses, produce and assignment holders. Topic 06 also reminds us that by the early sixteenth century, firearms and field artillery had entered Indian warfare more systematically; Panipat showed how technology mattered most when integrated with battle-organisation.

These changes influenced society unevenly. They strengthened capitals, roads, agrarian cores and military-fiscal extraction more than they democratised life. Monumental construction supported courtly urbanity; irrigation expanded cultivation; accounting practices sharpened control over intermediaries; and gunpowder-era methods began to reshape elite warfare.

Thus Sultanate technology influenced society chiefly by enlarging **state capacity, urban growth and military transformation**, while also deepening hierarchy and resource mobilisation.

Why this earns marks: It connects technology with irrigation, architecture, administration and Panipat without reducing the issue to weapons alone.

PYQ verification ledger and scope honesty

- No direct standalone UPSC PYQ devoted only to Timur's raid, the Sayyids, Bahlul, Sikandar or Ibrahim was verified locally in the bounded repository audit set used for this export.
- The package therefore uses **adjacent but honest** PYQs on chronology, Persian sources and Sultanate technology.
- No coaching-question stem is relabelled as an official UPSC PYQ.

Original broad-coverage MCQs

Broad MCQ 01

Question: Which statement best explains the crisis after Firuz Shah Tughlaq's death?

A. It emerged from succession conflict layered over hereditary office, factional elites and weakening central military-fiscal control. B. It was caused solely by Babur's artillery. C. It began only after Agra was founded. D. It reflected a sudden shift of Delhi to maritime trade.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The breakdown predates Timur and Panipat; it is rooted in structural and political weakening after 1388.

Broad MCQ 02

Question: Why did hereditary offices and assignments matter in the late Tughlaq phase?

A. They made every province a republic. B. They strengthened office-holding families and made later central discipline harder. C. They abolished military service. D. They converted iqtas into temples.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Hereditary claims reduced the centre's ability to reshuffle and discipline service elites.

Broad MCQ 03

Question: Which statement best reflects the fifteenth-century political pattern?

A. Delhi expanded while all regional states disappeared. B. No stable court culture survived outside Delhi. C. Delhi contracted while regional states such as Bengal, Gujarat, Malwa and Jaunpur remained active and durable. D. Timur governed India permanently from Delhi after 1398.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Topic 06 insists on regional vitality alongside Delhi's contraction.

Broad MCQ 04

Question: Timur's 1398 Indian invasion is most safely described as:

A. a peaceful pilgrimage. B. a full annexation of the subcontinent. C. a Gujarati naval expedition. D. a plundering raid on a weakened Delhi, clothed in legitimising language and followed by withdrawal.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: This wording captures motive, method and the absence of durable all-India occupation.

Broad MCQ 05

Question: What is the safest way to handle chronicler numbers for Timur's killings and captives?

A. Treat them as reported and often exaggerated claims while retaining the fact of real devastation. B. Quote them all literally as verified census data. C. Reject all violence because numbers differ. D. Use only modern round figures with no sources.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Source criticism means caution with numbers, not denial of violence.

Broad MCQ 06

Question: Which specific outcome of Timur's raid is securely supported in the local OCR?

A. He founded Agra. B. He carried away Indian artisans who were later employed in Samarqand. C. He permanently ruled Jaunpur. D. He introduced the gazz-i-Sikandari.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The artisan-transfer point is a core secure fact linking plunder to imperial construction elsewhere.

Broad MCQ 07

Question: What is the safest statement about Khizr Khan's legitimacy?

A. He ruled exactly like Alauddin Khalji without any legitimacy problem. B. He had no Timurid connection at all. C. He used Timurid association symbolically while ruling through local north-Indian bargaining. D. He was Timur's permanent viceroy over all India.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The Sayyid founder sat between symbolic Timurid connection and practical local rule.

Broad MCQ 08

Question: The Sayyid state is best described as:

A. an all-India agrarian democracy. B. a strong empire from Bengal to the Deccan. C. a maritime customs regime. D. a Delhi-centred weak sovereignty dependent on tribute, negotiation and limited coercive reach.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Delhi's symbol survived, but not the wide command structure of the high Sultanate.

Broad MCQ 09

Question: The *Tarikh-i-Mubarak Shahi* is associated with:

A. Yahya bin Ahmad Sirhindi. B. Sharaf al-Din Yazdi. C. Ibn Battuta. D. Abbas Sarwani.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Yahya bin Ahmad Sirhindi is the key named chronicler for the later Tughlaq-early Sayyid world.

Broad MCQ 10

Question: Which phrase best captures Afghan elite political expectations under the Lodis?

A. Absolute rejection of monarchy in every form. B. The ruler as first among powerful equals, with consultation and honour-sharing claims among nobles. C. Automatic acceptance of Balban-like distance. D. Complete absence of lineage politics.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Afghan nobles often expected status, consultation and a distributive share in power.

Broad MCQ 11

Question: Why is Abbas Sarwani's "came like locusts" line used cautiously?

A. Because it proves Afghans never came to India. B. Because it was written by Timur. C. Because it is later rhetorical language that may exaggerate the scale while still preserving memory of strong Afghan inflow. D. Because it refers to Portuguese traders.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Later Afghan histories can preserve memory but also heighten effect.

Broad MCQ 12

Question: Which achievement is most securely associated with Bahlul Lodi?

A. Building Firozabad. B. Replacing Babur at Kabul. C. Conquering Vijayanagara. D. Defeating and annexing Sharqi Jaunpur after building an Afghan Punjab-Delhi base.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Bahlul's major durable success was the consolidation of Lodi power through the defeat of Jaunpur.

Broad MCQ 13

Question: Why was the founding of Agra under Sikandar Lodi historically significant?

A. It provided a strategic centre closer to the doab, Rajasthan, Malwa and Gujarat-facing theatre. B. It was built as a coastal harbour for Indian Ocean trade. C. It marked Sikandar's withdrawal from north India. D. It abolished all rivalry with Afghan nobles.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Agra was chosen for military-geographical reasons, not as a decorative urban project alone.

Broad MCQ 14

Question: The gazz-i-Sikandari refers to:

A. a field artillery unit. B. a standard unit of measurement associated with Sikandar Lodi's administration. C. a Timurid cavalry formation. D. a Sayyid coin type.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: It is a classic administrative-marker fact tied to measurement and revenue supervision.

Broad MCQ 15

Question: Which description best captures Sikandar Lodi's religious-cultural profile?

A. A purely liberal ruler with no coercive religious action. B. An anti-literary ruler hostile to Persian learning. C. An administratively able ruler whose orthodoxy coexisted with significant literary patronage and cultural activity. D. A ruler who excluded all Hindus from office and language learning completely.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The safe reading is mixed and source-bounded, not one-word moral labelling.

Broad MCQ 16

Question: Which factor most directly opened the way for Babur's intervention against Ibrahim Lodi?

A. The instant collapse of all regional states. B. Portuguese naval support to Daulat Khan. C. The disappearance of Punjab politics. D. Conflict between Ibrahim and major Afghan nobles such as Daulat Khan and Alam Khan.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Internal Lodi fracture created the political corridor through which Babur advanced.

Broad MCQ 17

Question: Which statement about Panipat is correct?

A. Babur's army was smaller but fought with a more integrated battle-system of artillery, carts, tactical gaps and cavalry manoeuvre. B. Ibrahim Lodi had no elephants at all. C. Babur deliberately fought without any field preparation. D. The battle was won before armies met.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Coordination, not mere numbers, explains Babur's battlefield success.

Broad MCQ 18

Question: The tulughma/tulghuma tactic is best understood as:

A. temple endowment under the Sayyids. B. a flanking and enveloping cavalry manoeuvre within Babur's battle-plan. C. grain taxation under Sikandar. D. a chronicle by Yahya bin Ahmad.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Tulughma refers to mobile divisions used to envelop and outmanoeuvre the enemy.

Broad MCQ 19

Question: Which explanation best rejects the "guns alone" myth?

A. Artillery was irrelevant. B. Ibrahim lacked war elephants. C. Babur's success came from firearms integrated with leadership, fortification, manoeuvre and Lodi political weakness. D. Victory was caused only by Timurid bloodline.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Topic 06 treats technology as effective only when embedded in organisation and command.

Broad MCQ 20

Question: Which statement about the date of Panipat is safest in this repository's usage?

A. The exact date is unknowable and must never be mentioned. B. The battle occurred in 1498. C. The repository rejects all textbook dates. D. The battle is commonly given as 21 April 1526, but repository caution notes that some local source handling has also preserved 20 April; the key is to flag the variance honestly if needed.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The export follows repository caution rather than pretending there is no date-variant issue in the local source trail.

Broad MCQ 21

Question: Which statement best captures the immediate result of Babur's victory?

A. It ended Lodi dynastic rule at the centre but did not instantly create uncontested Mughal rule across India. B. It erased all Afghan resistance immediately. C. It transferred power directly to the Portuguese. D. It made Bengal part of Babur's secure empire the same week.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Panipat was decisive dynastically, not immediately final territorially.

Broad MCQ 22

Question: Which administrative feature is most visible in the Lodi recovery of the Delhi-Agra core?

A. Complete abandonment of revenue supervision. B. Greater attention to account-checking, measurement, roads and agrarian order. C. Refusal to found or support urban centres. D. Replacement of cavalry by an all-infantry militia.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Lodi recovery worked through military-fiscal rebuilding, not administrative withdrawal.

Broad MCQ 23

Question: Which statement about Sayyid-Lodi architecture is safest?

A. It had no connection with later Mughal garden-tomb development. B. It abandoned all tomb building. C. It includes square and octagonal tomb forms, high platforms and transitional features important for later Mughal funerary architecture. D. It was exclusively wooden architecture.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The late Sultanate-Lodi phase is an architectural bridge, especially in tomb design and landscape setting.

Broad MCQ 24

Question: Why should Bara Gumbad and Shish Gumbad be handled carefully in Topic 06?

A. Because they belong only to ancient history. B. Because they are Jain cave monasteries. C. Because they were built by Babur in Kabul. D. Because exact attribution and chronology debates require caution even when they illustrate the broader Lodi architectural world.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Topic 06 uses them as bounded examples, not as a licence for overconfident monument trivia.

Broad MCQ 25

Question: Which source is most closely associated with the Timurid courtly victory tradition?

A. Sharaf al-Din Ali Yazdi's *Zafarnama*. B. Yahya bin Ahmad Sirhindi's *Tarikh-i-Mubarak Shahi*. C. Afif's *Tarikh-i-Firuz Shahi*. D. Abbas Sarwani's Afghan narrative.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Yazdi is central to the Timurid courtly narrative, though still agenda-laden.

Broad MCQ 26

Question: What is the safest statement about the *Tuzuk-i-Timuri* / *Malfuzat-i-Timuri* tradition?

A. It is Babur's memoir under another name. B. It must be treated with authenticity caution and used comparatively, not literally as unquestioned autobiography. C. It is a Mughal land-revenue manual. D. It proves Timur intended a settled all-India empire.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The source is valuable chiefly as a source problem and ideological tradition, not as transparent self-authored fact.

Broad MCQ 27

Question: Which statement best uses the *Baburnama* safely for Topic 06?

A. It is useless because memoirs are always false. B. It is a neutral military log with no self-fashioning. C. It is a vivid first-person source for campaign detail and self-representation, best checked against politics, material evidence and later outcomes. D. It was written by Ibrahim Lodi after Panipat.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The memoir is exceptionally valuable, but still a ruler's account.

Broad MCQ 28

Question: Which summary best fits fifteenth-century north India?

A. Uniform economic collapse from Bengal to Gujarat. B. A timeless war of races. C. A fully restored unitary Delhi empire. D. Political fragmentation at the old centre combined with regional state vitality and selective economic recovery.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: This is the core interpretive sentence of the topic.

Broad MCQ 29

Question: Which statement about the economy and society of the age is strongest?

A. Political fragmentation did not prevent recovery in centres such as Delhi, Agra, Punjab and the doab, especially under the later Lodis. B. All trade routes disappeared permanently after 1398. C. Persian ceased to matter in administration. D. Urban life vanished from north India for a century.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Topic 06 avoids confusing political contraction with total economic death.

Broad MCQ 30

Question: What is the best distinction between symbolic claim and durable rule?

A. They are always identical in medieval history. B. A ruler could possess khutba, coin or dynastic symbolism without commanding deep and stable coercive control everywhere. C. Symbols never mattered politically. D. Durable rule required no revenue or army.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: This distinction is crucial for reading the Sayyids and also Timur's shadow over Delhi.

Broad MCQ 31

Question: The "Delhi to Palam" trope is mainly used to indicate:

A. Delhi's maritime expansion. B. the building of a new river canal to Palam. C. the dramatic shrinkage of the Delhi sultan's effective authority and prestige. D. the Sayyid conquest of all Punjab.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: It is a literary image of contraction and humiliation, not a cartographic measurement.

Broad MCQ 32

Question: Which concluding thesis is most appropriate for Topic 06?

A. The Delhi Sultanate fell only because Timur attacked. B. The Lodis failed because Afghans were biologically unfit for monarchy. C. Panipat was purely a gunpowder miracle. D. The decline of Delhi was a long structural and political transition in which regionalisation, elite fracture, fiscal-military strain, Timur's raid and Babur's organised intervention all mattered.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: This is the full multi-causal conclusion expected in a high-quality GS-I answer.

Remedial trap MCQs

Remedial MCQ 01

Question: Which statement is false?

A. Delhi's decline automatically means that all of India experienced total collapse in the same way. B. Regional states could remain active while Delhi weakened. C. A shrinking centre and resilient provinces can coexist. D. Political fragmentation and selective economic recovery are compatible.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The main trap of the topic is to confuse Delhi's contraction with India-wide death.

Remedial MCQ 02

Question: Which statement is the strongest correction to the phrase "Timur conquered India"?

A. He never entered India at all. B. He conducted a devastating raid on Delhi and the north-west, then withdrew rather than building durable all-India rule. C. He ruled from Agra for twenty years. D. He was defeated before reaching Punjab.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Topic 06 distinguishes raid, plunder and symbolic aftermath from settled conquest.

Remedial MCQ 03

Question: Which statement is correct?

A. The Sayyids restored the empire of Alauddin Khalji in full. B. Khizr Khan had no relation at all to Timurid legitimacy claims. C. The Sayyid polity is best seen as weak sovereignty centred on Delhi rather than as a massive reconquest empire. D. The Sayyids permanently eliminated Jaunpur and Malwa.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The Sayyids mattered symbolically, but their coercive reach remained limited.

Remedial MCQ 04

Question: Which statement best corrects the phrase "Afghan equality"?

A. Afghan nobles rejected every kind of rank. B. Afghan politics meant modern universal democracy. C. Afghan rulers always partitioned India peacefully. D. Afghan elite culture often involved strong claims to consultation and shared honour among nobles, but it was still embedded in hierarchical state politics.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: "Equality" here is an elite political idiom, not a modern social doctrine.

Remedial MCQ 05

Question: Which statement about Sikandar Lodi is most misleading?

A. His reign can be described simply as either complete tolerance or total civilisational darkness. B. He founded Agra for strategic reasons. C. He is associated with gazz-i-Sikandari and account scrutiny. D. His reign mixed stronger administration with sharper juristic-religious policies.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Topic 06 rejects flat moral binaries; the other three statements are defensible and source-grounded.

Remedial MCQ 06

Question: Which statement best corrects the image of Ibrahim Lodi as merely a passive weakling?

A. He had no political will whatsoever. B. He attempted to strengthen monarchy, but this sharpened conflict with Afghan nobles and relatives. C. He voluntarily surrendered to Babur before battle. D. He ruled only Kashmir.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Ibrahim's failure came partly from an assertive but politically costly centralising push.

Remedial MCQ 07

Question: Which statement about Panipat is correct?

A. Babur won without any preparation or tactical innovation. B. Firearms were irrelevant to the battle. C. Panipat shows how firearms mattered when combined with fortification, manoeuvre and leadership. D. Ibrahim's army was politically united and tactically superior.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The trap is to isolate guns from the battle-system that made them effective.

Remedial MCQ 08

Question: Which statement best corrects the phrase "1526 instantly created the Mughal Empire in all India"?

A. Babur never took Delhi. B. Panipat was a small skirmish of no consequence. C. Ibrahim survived and ruled for ten more years. D. Panipat ended Lodi dynastic rule at the centre, but Babur still faced Rajput and Afghan resistance before wider consolidation.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Topic 06 repeatedly distinguishes dynastic victory from full imperial consolidation.

Remedial MCQ 09

Question: Which statement is correct?

A. The *Tuzuk/Malfuzat* tradition needs authenticity caution and comparative reading. B. It is unquestionably Timur's autograph manuscript. C. It completely replaces Yazdi and Indian chronicles. D. It is a revenue survey of Agra.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Source criticism is central to this topic.

Remedial MCQ 10

Question: Which statement best distinguishes Jaunpur in Topic 06?

A. It was irrelevant to Delhi. B. It was the strongest eastern rival whose defeat mattered to Bahlul Lodi's consolidation. C. It was conquered by Timur and ruled from Samarqand. D. It functioned only as a temple town without state power.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Jaunpur is a serious regional-state actor, not a decorative footnote.

Remedial MCQ 11

Question: Which statement is correct?

A. Every route and market died permanently after 1398. B. Urban life vanished permanently from the Delhi-Agra region after Timur. C. Political fragmentation did not prevent roads, agrarian recovery and urban revival in parts of north India. D. Persian stopped spreading in administration.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Recovery in the Delhi-Agra-doab core is a major counter-trap in the topic.

Remedial MCQ 12

Question: Which statement best captures the architectural value of the Sayyid-Lodi phase?

A. It has no relation to Mughal architecture. B. It is valuable only for fort walls. C. It should be ignored because chronology debates exist. D. It offers transitional tomb forms, platform use and garden settings that help explain later Mughal funerary developments.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Caution about individual monuments does not cancel the broader architectural significance of the phase.

Original solved Mains questions

Mains 01 - 10 marks

Question: Explain the structural causes of the fragmentation of the Delhi Sultanate after 1388. (Answer in 150 words)

Model answer:

- **Claim:** The fragmentation after 1388 was structural, not merely the product of weak successors.
- **Evidence / source line:** Satish Chandra's concise and Part I discussions emphasise succession disorder, noble-centre conflict, provincial assertion and geographical-regional factors. Topic 05 adds Firuz's hereditary office and weakened military discipline.
- **Mechanism:** Open succession encouraged civil war; hereditary offices strengthened service families; muqtis and regional commanders retained resources; cavalry-fort maintenance strained finances; distance and ecology favoured provincial autonomy; local agrarian-commercial bases could sustain rival courts.
- **Significance:** Once Delhi's aura dimmed, Bengal, Gujarat, Malwa and Jaunpur no longer behaved like temporary rebels but as viable states.
- **Limitation:** Rulers still mattered; structure did not make collapse automatic.
- **Verdict:** The Sultanate fragmented because institutions of succession, extraction and command were too weak to survive repeated shocks.

Why this earns marks: It moves beyond the cliché of weak successors and builds a five-factor answer with causation.

Mains 02 - 10 marks

Question: Assess the impact of Timur's invasion on the Delhi Sultanate. (Answer in 150 words)

Model answer:

- **Claim:** Timur's 1398 raid was a devastating catalyst, not the sole cause of the Sultanate's decline.
- **Evidence / source line:** Local OCR stresses sack, killings, plunder and the carrying away of artisans; the concise volume also says Timur's political effect was limited because he did not stay, yet the invasion marked the end of strong Delhi rule.
- **Mechanism:** The raid destroyed life and wealth in Delhi, deepened prestige collapse, enlarged the political vacuum and encouraged frontier and provincial actors such as Khizr Khan.
- **Significance:** It accelerated transition from late Tughlaq weakness to Sayyid weak sovereignty.
- **Limitation:** Regional vitality elsewhere continued; India as a whole was not conquered or permanently destroyed.
- **Verdict:** Timur's invasion was a decisive blow to Delhi's core authority, but it operated within a longer process of structural fragmentation already underway.

Why this earns marks: It balances devastation, causation and continuity without either minimising or apocalyptic exaggeration.

Mains 03 - 15 marks

Question: "The Sayyid dynasty preserved the symbol of Delhi more than the substance of empire." Examine. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

- **Claim:** The statement is substantially correct.
- **Evidence / source line:** Topic 06 owner files and local OCR place Khizr Khan's Delhi recovery in 1414 under a Timurid legitimacy shadow, while also noting that the Sayyids never became strong empire-builders. The dynasty faced Khokhars in Punjab, Mewatis and Sharqi Jaunpur.
- **Mechanism:** Delhi remained valuable as a symbol of sovereignty, khutba and courtly precedence. However, control beyond the core required negotiated tribute, intermittent campaigns and compromise with local chiefs. The gap between claim and enforcement widened.
- **Significance:** The Sayyid phase shows how a state can survive through **symbolic centrality** even after the high-capacity imperial machine has thinned out. It explains why Bahlul Lodi could later take Delhi and still inherit

prestige from the city.

- **Limitation:** Weak sovereignty should not be read as zero importance. Mubarak Shah especially tried to act more assertively, and Delhi still mattered strategically.
- **Verdict:** The Sayyids preserved the throne's symbolic relevance, but not the broad coercive reach of the Khalji-Tughlaq zenith.

Why this earns marks: It defines symbolism and substance separately and uses them as analytical categories, not rhetoric.

Mains 04 - 15 marks

Question: Analyse Sikandar Lodi's contribution to the reconstruction of north-Indian monarchy. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

- **Claim:** Sikandar Lodi was the most effective Lodi ruler and the chief architect of the dynasty's administrative consolidation.
- **Evidence / source line:** Local OCR credits him with making nobles honour farmans, demanding jagir accounts, ensuring justice, safe roads, cheap prices, abolishing grain octroi, introducing gazz-i-Sikandari and founding Agra in 1506.
- **Mechanism:** He reduced the autonomy of Afghan nobles through court discipline and audit; strengthened the military-fiscal core through measurement and supervision; and shifted strategic focus eastward and southward through Agra. Agrarian and road security improved the revenue base.
- **Significance:** Under Sikandar, Delhi recovered enough to become once more a serious north-Indian monarchy rather than merely a symbolic seat. His reign also demonstrates that political fragmentation did not preclude material recovery.
- **Limitation:** His coercive religious actions and orthodoxy complicate any celebratory picture; moreover, noble bargaining remained structurally unresolved and resurfaced sharply under Ibrahim.
- **Verdict:** Sikandar reconstructed monarchy through discipline, supervision and strategic urban policy, but could not eliminate the contradictions of Afghan-Lodi kingship.

Why this earns marks: It joins political authority, revenue supervision and urban geography in one integrated answer.

Mains 05 - 20 marks

Question: Panipat (1526) was won by Babur not because of firearms alone, but because of a superior military-political system. Discuss. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

- **Claim:** Firearms mattered, but Panipat was fundamentally a victory of coordinated system over disjointed mass.
- **Evidence / source line:** Part II OCR names Ustad Ali and Mustafa, cart-lines tied by rawhide ropes, tactical gaps, artillery and tulughma manoeuvre. It also stresses Ibrahim's larger host and the continuing factional weakness of the Lodi camp.
- **Mechanism:** Babur used artillery from prepared positions, protected it with carts, preserved mobility through gaps, and enveloped with tulughma cavalry. This tactical design multiplied the value of firearms. Leadership cohesion mattered equally: Babur commanded one organised plan, whereas Ibrahim drew upon a politically strained coalition less capable of flexible response.
- **Political setting:** Daulat Khan and Alam Khan had already exposed Lodi fracture. Thus battlefield technology rested on prior political disunity.
- **Significance:** Panipat marks the transition to a new style of north-Indian warfare in which gunpowder, fortification and manoeuvre increasingly worked together.
- **Limitation:** It would still be wrong to claim that all Indian polities were helpless before guns; later battles show adaptation.
- **Verdict:** Babur won because firearms were embedded in superior organisation, command, fieldcraft and political timing.

Why this earns marks: It directly addresses the word "alone" and integrates technology with tactics, leadership and politics.

Mains 06 - 20 marks

Question: "The decline of the Delhi Sultanate was also an age of regionalisation, selective recovery and historical transition." Evaluate. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

- **Claim:** The statement is the most accurate way to read the fifteenth and early sixteenth centuries.
- **Evidence / source line:** Part I explicitly warns against reading the age simply as decadence and decline. Bengal, Gujarat, Malwa, Jaunpur and other regional powers remained active. Topic 06 also shows Delhi's urban-political disruption after Timur, Sayyid weak sovereignty, Lodi recovery and Panipat's non-finality.
- **Mechanism:** After 1388, succession disorder, fiscal-military strain and provincial autonomy weakened Delhi. Timur's 1398 raid deepened that crisis. Yet regional agrarian-commercial bases sustained alternative courts and cultural centres. Under the Lodis, especially Sikandar, the Delhi-Agra-doab core recovered through roads, supervision, measurement and strategic urban policy.
- **Transition dimension:** Babur's victory at Panipat ended Lodi dynastic rule but did not erase administrative continuities or regional resistance. Thus the period links the high Sultanate to the early Mughal order.
- **Limitation:** Regionalisation should not obscure the severe damage suffered by Delhi itself; nor should recovery be overstated into full imperial restoration.
- **Verdict:** The age was one of contraction at the centre, vitality in the regions and eventually a military-political transition to Mughal supremacy.

Why this earns marks: It avoids both collapse-romance and progress-romance, which is exactly what examiners reward in higher-order answers.